with a leader, but when a normal guy comes with a thaila [bag], he understands things differently and engages with him differently.'[58]

BJP vs Congress vs JD-S: A Ground Game Example from Karnataka

Parties do not win elections through organisational structures alone. That is not the claim being made here. The point is that building a ground game gives the party a better chance of success. In close elections, it could make all the difference.

In Karnataka, for example, the Bengaluru-based political journalist Sandeep Moudgal pointed out what this kind of party organisation means in real terms for the BJP, in relation to its political opponents—the Congress and the Janata Dal (Secular) (JD-S). 'When they hold campaign rallies, for Congress and JD-S, this means getting together a crowd of people. Congress and JD-S both rely on local leaders to get people in for a rally. In Congress, when they organise a Rahul Gandhi rally here, for example, they would pass instructions from Delhi to someone here, who would then pass instructions to the next ten leaders, then to the next ten and then next ten leaders. By the end, it will be very haphazard. In the BJP, when a senior leader visits, it is different. They will first talk directly to the ten leaders on the ground. Then they would send a recce team, followed by a dedicated team of three-four leaders which comes from outside to each place to do ground work and to ensure coordination between local people and people from outside. BJP has booth-level workers in 80 per cent of booths. BJP's organisation is much more advanced compared to Congress, and the building blocks of their structure are the difference. The focus in BJP is on booth workers and efficiency. Yeddyurappa did the ground work initially, now they have worked to build an organisational structure around that foundation.'[59]

Interestingly, the Congress tried to emulate this strategy in the 2018 assembly elections in Karnataka. Digvijay Singh, as the state-in-charge for the Congress, tried to build a cadre mentality at the booth level. But, at the end of the day, 'Congress is a brass party. It is the leader which generates a crowd in Congress, not the other